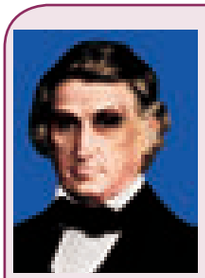
intestine. It contains minute finger like projections called **villi** (one millimeter in length) where absorption of food takes place. They are approximately 4 million in number. Internally, each villus contains fine blood capillaries and lacteal tubes,

The small intestine serves both for digestion and absorption. It receives the bile from liver and the pancreatic juice from pancreas in the duodenum. The intestinal glands secrete the intestinal juices.



William Beaumont (1785-1853)

William Beaumont was a surgeon who was known as the 'Father of Gastric Physiology'. Based on his observations he concluded that the stomach's strong hydrochloric acid played a key role in digestion.

Liver: It is the largest digestive gland of the body which is reddish brown in colour. It is divided into two main lobes, right and left lobes. The right lobe is larger than the left lobe. On the under surface of the liver, gall bladder is present. The liver cells secrete **bile** which is temporarily stored in the gall bladder. Bile is released into small intestine when food enters in it. It has **bile salts** (sodium glycolate and sodium tauraglycolate) and **bile pigments** (bilirubin and biliviridin). Bile salts help in the digestion of fats by bringing about their **emulsification** (conversion of large fat droplets into small ones).

Functions of Liver

- Controls blood sugar and amino acid levels.
- Synthesizes foetal red blood cells.
- Produces fibrinogen and prothrombin, used for clotting of blood.
- Destroys red blood cells.
- Stores iron, copper, vitamins A and D.
- Produces heparin (an anticoagulant).
- Excretes toxic and metallic poisons.
- Detoxifies substances including drugs and alcohol.

Pancreas: It is a lobed, leaf shaped gland situated between the stomach and duodenum. **Pancreas** acts both as an **exocrine gland** and as an **endocrine gland**. The exocrine part of the pancreatic gland secretes pancreatic juice which contains three enzymes- lipase, trypsin and amylase which acts on fats, proteins and starch respectively. The gland's upper surface bears the **islets of Langerhans** which have endocrine cells and secrete hormones in which **α (alpha) cells** secrete **glucagon** and **β (beta) cells** secrete **insulin**.

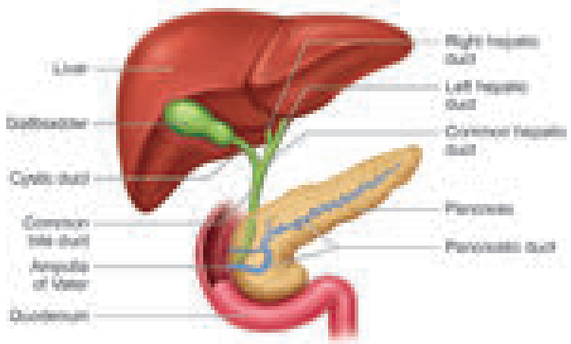


Figure 20.4 Bile duct and Pancreatic duct opening into duodenum

The intestinal glands secrete intestinal juice called **succus entericus** which contains enzymes like maltase, lactase, sucrase and lipase which act in an alkaline medium. From the duodenum the food is slowly moved down to ileum, where the digested food gets absorbed

a. Absorption of food: Absorption is the process by which nutrients obtained after digestion are absorbed by villi and circulated throughout the body by blood and lymph and supplied to all body cells according to their requirements.

b. Assimilation of food: Assimilation means the incorporation of the absorbed food materials into the tissue cells as their internal and homogenous component. The final products of fat digestion (fatty acids and glycerol) are again converted into fats and

IX_SCI_EM_Unit-20_BIO.indd 237 06-02-2020 13:20:55